Organizational Design & Management Syllabus

High School

2026–2027

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor	Email	Room Location & Hours
Penny Burciaga	Penny@rivertech.me	The Café — Tuesdays, 10:25–11:05 AM

GENERAL INFORMATION

Course Summary

Organizational Design & Management is a 35-week course that teaches students how real organizations are built and run by having them build and run one. Working in teams, students found an invented company in Week 4 and develop it continuously across every functional area of a business, from legal formation and governance through funding, structure, people, operations, marketing, sales, finance, legal protection, and change. This running company is the spine of the course: it turns 35 otherwise-separate topics into one continuous, real-world experience.

Note: modifications may be made to accommodate school needs. Breadth and depth of content may be adjusted depending on demonstrated competency of learning objectives.

How the Course Is Taught

The course runs on a roughly 95% activity / 5% instruction model, consistent with the school's hands-on mission. In each 30-minute session, a concept is framed in two to three minutes, students spend the bulk of the time doing, and the learning is consolidated in a short debrief. Concepts are discovered through the activity rather than delivered before it. Students experience a bottleneck, a culture clash, or a failed handoff first, and name the principle afterward.

Functional Coverage

The curriculum is mapped against the full set of business functional areas so no core discipline is missed. Major functions each receive dedicated weeks; secondary functions (supply chain, IT/data, PR and crisis communications) are addressed through scenario cards embedded in later units and the capstone crisis round, giving honest coverage without inflating the calendar. Content cross-over allows for the reinforcement of previously learned objectives.

Relationship to the Leadership Mindset Course

Some students take the parallel Leadership Mindset course, which builds an individual operating system (lead yourself, then lead others). This course is the collective counterpart: what happens when individually-led people must build a structure, culture, and management system together. Frameworks shared between the two — Tuckman's stages, SBI feedback, Circle of Control, PDCA — function here as reinforcement in a new context. The course stands fully on its own.

ASSESSMENT

Assessment is performance-based. Students are evaluated on the artifacts they produce for their company (org chart, SOPs, budget, service policy, contract, risk audit) and on the capstone, where teams present their complete organization to an authentic audience and respond to a surprise crisis scenario in real time.

Guest Speakers

Guest speakers representing various organizational types may share their lessons learned, as scheduled.

Use of AI

Use of ChatGPT, Claude Co-work, and Grok Imagine may be used to complete course objectives.

COURSE SCHEDULE

Course at a Glance

Unit	Weeks	Focus
Introductory Class	1	Introductions, expectations, ice breaker, overview of course
Types & Governance	2–5	Org types, legal structure, boards, oversight
Funding	6–8	Funding sources, pitching, debt vs. equity
Structure & Roles	9–11	Org structures, decision rights, org chart
HR & Payroll	12–15	Hiring, interviews, payroll, compensation
Operations & Systems	16–17	Production flow, bottlenecks, SOPs, scaling
Marketing, Sales & Customers	18–22	Research, messaging, selling, service recovery
Financials	23–26	Budgeting
Legal & Risk	27–29	Contracts & risk management
Change & Org Health	30–32	Adapting, resistance, retrospectives
Capstone	33–35	Showcase

Learning Objectives by Functional Area

Objectives are written as observable student outcomes and tagged with their level on Bloom's Taxonomy. Consistent with the activity-based model, most objectives sit at the Apply, Analyze, Evaluate, and Create levels — students demonstrate understanding by doing, deciding, and building rather than by recalling.

Functional Area	Week(s)	Students will be able to... (Bloom's level in brackets)
FORMATION & GOVERNANCE		
Formation & Legal Structure	2–3	Classify real organizations by type (for-profit, nonprofit, government, cooperative, hybrid) and justify edge cases. [Analyze] Organizational design vs. management [Understand] Select an appropriate legal structure for an invented company. [Evaluate]
Governance & Boards	4–5	Distinguish decisions that belong to a board from those that belong to management. [Analyze] Conduct a structured board meeting with an agenda, roles, and a logged decision. [Apply]
Strategy & Planning	Embedded	Articulate a clear mission, vision, and core values [Create] — HOMEWORK Set specific, measurable goals [Evaluate] Position the company against a competitor by identifying a point of difference. [Analyze]
MONEY		
Finance & Funding	6–8	Match funding sources (revenue, loans, investment, grants, donations) to organizational scenarios. [Apply] Review and analyze a budget and where budget cuts can be made [Analyze]

Functional Area	Week(s)	Students will be able to... (Bloom's level in brackets)
		Management of financials [Understand]
STRUCTURE & PEOPLE		
Organizational Structure	9–11	Compare functional, divisional, and flat structures by their effect on speed and output. [Analyze] Design an org chart for the running company. What work can be done by AI agents? [Create] — HOMEWORK Management principles of people & AI agents [Understand]
Human Resources	12–14, 17	Write role descriptions that define responsibilities for a company's first hires. [Create] — HOMEWORK Conduct and evaluate an interview using a defined hiring rubric. [Evaluate] Management — what's in a performance review [Understand]
Payroll & Compensation	15	Employee vs. Contractor vs. Vendor [Understand] Calculate the difference between gross pay, take-home pay, and total employer cost. [Apply] Explain how taxes, withholding, and benefits affect both employee and employer. [Understand]
MAKING & DELIVERING		
Operations	16	Set up a production process. [Apply] Identify the bottleneck in a process and explain how it limits total output. [Analyze] Propose and test a change that improves flow, quality, or efficiency. [Create]
Operational Systems	17	Document a repeatable process as a written SOP or process map. [Create] Explain why operational systems let an organization scale beyond any single person. [Understand]
CUSTOMERS		
Marketing	18–19	Build a customer profile from primary research (interviewing a target market). [Create] — HOMEWORK Tools for marketing & advertising depending on business type.
Sales	20	Sales strategies. [Analyze] Choose a primary sales strategy for your business and explain why [Apply]
Customer Service	21–22	Resolve a range of customer complaints in real time and reflect on what turned each around. [Apply] Write a service-recovery policy for the company (what we do when we get it wrong). [Create]
MONEY		
Financials & Accounting	23–26	Build a basic budget from raw revenue and expense data. [Apply] Where do you reallocate when required to cut spending. [Create] Diagnose the financial health of a company by reading its numbers. [Evaluate]
PROTECTION		
Legal & Risk Management	27–29	Types of contracts and use cases [Understand] Audit the company for its top risks. [Evaluate]
CAPSTONE		
Business Presentations	30–32	Students present their business (basic type, operations, budget, and org. chart).